Covariates of Academic Burnout Among UCSD Students: A Pilot Study

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Introduction

- Burnout is caused by chronic and overwhelming stress that leads to exhaustion (Maslach et al., 2001)
- Burnout was initially studied in human service professions, however, it has been found that students also experience burnout (Jacobs & Dodd, 2003)
- Academic burnout is an extension of career burnout because student responsibilities resemble work (Lin & Huang, 2014)
- Burnout is associated with poor sleep (Andrade et al., 2023)
- Long commute times are linked with insomnia (Hori et al., 2020)
- Higher levels of commute stress are associated with burnout (Amponsah-Tawiah et al., 2016)

Hypotheses

1. Poor sleep quality would be associated with higher levels of academic burnout
2. Longer weekly commute times would be associated with poor sleep quality
3. Longer commute times would be associated with higher levels of academic burnout

Method

Measures

- Copenhagen Burnout Inventory (Kristensen et al., 2005)
- Pittsburgh Sleep Quality Index (Buysse et al., 1989)
- Participants were asked to report their weekly commute times

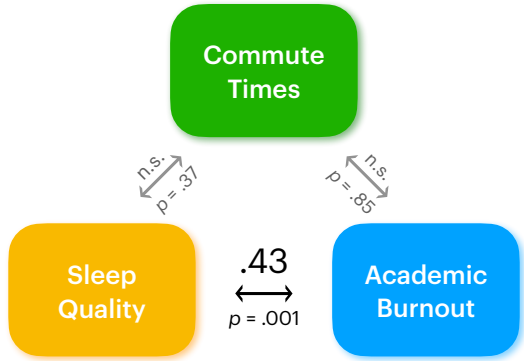
Procedure

- Participants were recruited in-person, through social media platforms (e.g., Instagram, Discord), and student clubs
- UCSD undergraduate and graduate students who were 18 years old or older completed a self-report questionnaire
- Data was collected one week before finals week
- We used a correlational study design to determine the associations between academic burnout, sleep quality, and commute times

Participant Demographics

- 55 UC San Diego students (98% were undergraduates)
- Ages 18 to 32 (M = 20.65)
- Predominantly self-identified as Asian (51%)
- Gender: 62% female, 36% male, 2% other

Results



Units and Class Standing

- **Enrolled unit count** was not significantly associated with burnout, $r(53) = -.12$, $p = .39$
- **Class standing** was not significantly associated with burnout, $r(53) = -.10$, $p = .49$

Burnout Scores

- 73% of our sample reported moderate to high burnout
- Our sample reported levels of burnout similar to United States child welfare workers

56.30
UCSD Sample Burnout Score

Our Study

56.75
Child Welfare Workers Burnout Score

Leake et al. (2017)

Variable	1.	2.	3.	*M*	*SD*
1. Academic Burnout				56.30	17.96
2. Sleep Quality	.43**			8.18	3.33
3. Commute Time	.03	–.12		80.89	77.38

**$p < .01$

Directions for Future Research

- Future studies can examine unstudied variables (e.g., work hours, time spent in class, GPA, commute stress)
- A study with a larger sample is needed to accurately clarify the non-significant associations we observed
- Further research can be done to determine if sleep quality and commute times also are associated with personal burnout

Conclusion

- Our findings suggest UCSD students experience high levels of burnout near finals week
- Highlights the potential importance of sleep in preventing burnout
- Commute times, number of enrolled units, and class standing do not seem to covary with academic burnout
- UCSD should provide additional support for student wellbeing in order to reduce academic burnout rates

Limitation

- Our sample was not fully random (about 15 responses were obtained through social network)

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